



Power BI Viewer

USER GUIDE

Sign in once and see all your Power BI apps, reports, and dashboards in one clean desktop window — with live data-freshness at a glance and a hands-free slideshow for wall displays.

Windows & Mac · Your app version is shown in **Settings** → **About**

1 Welcome

Power BI Viewer is one tidy desktop window for everything your team publishes to you in Power BI — apps, reports, and dashboards. No browser tabs. No repeated logins.

Sign in once — that's it

You sign in with your normal Microsoft 365 work account **one time**. The app remembers you, even after you close it or restart your computer. Everything inside — including Power BI Apps — uses that same sign-in, so nothing asks you to log in again.

What you get

Everything in one place

Your Power BI Apps, plus any reports and dashboards shared with you.

Always-current data

The toolbar shows exactly when your data was last refreshed, and reports can update themselves the moment new data arrives.

Instant search

Press **Ctrl** + **K** and find any report, dashboard, app, or workspace as you type.

Wall-display slideshow

A full-screen, hands-free presentation mode for TVs and lobby screens.

New here? Start with these

Read [Install & sign in](#), then [Power BI Apps](#) — that is where most of your content lives. If you run a wall display, also read [Slideshow & wall displays](#).

2 Install & sign in

Download

Your administrator shares a download link. Pick the file for your computer:

- **Windows:** the file ending in `Windows-Setup.exe`
- **Mac with Apple chip (M1/M2/M3):** the `Mac-arm64.zip` file
- **Mac with Intel chip:** the `Mac-x64.zip` file

Not sure which Mac you have?

Click the Apple menu → **About This Mac**. If it says "Apple M1/M2/M3", pick **arm64**. If it says "Intel", pick **x64**.

Install on Windows

- 1 Double-click the downloaded `...Windows-Setup.exe`.
- 2 Windows may show a blue **"Windows protected your PC"** screen. This is expected — see the note below.
- 3 Click **More info**, then **Run anyway**.
- 4 The installer finishes in a few seconds. No admin rights needed.
- 5 Open **Power BI Viewer** from the Start menu or desktop shortcut.

Why does Windows warn me?

The app does not yet carry a paid publisher certificate, so Windows is cautious the first time. It is your own organization's app and safe to run. You will only see this during install — not every day.

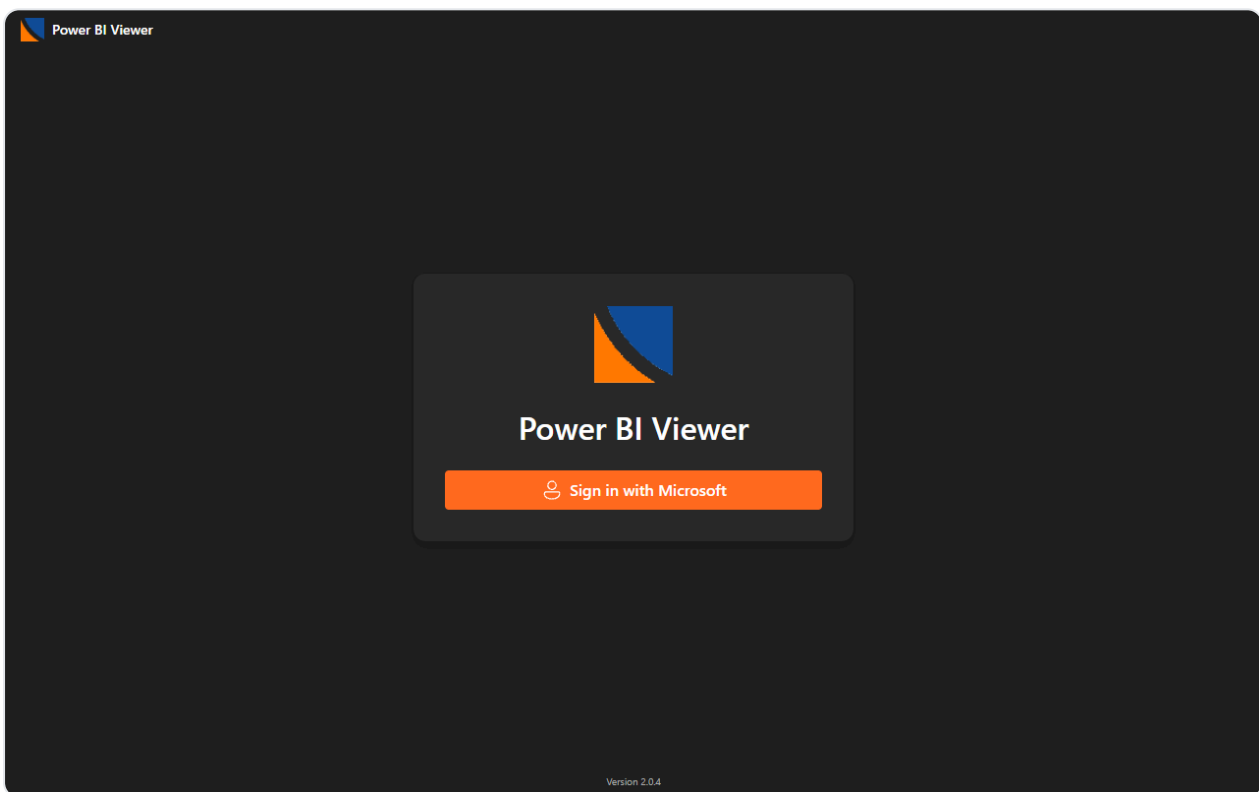
Install on Mac

- 1 Double-click the downloaded `.zip` to unzip it.
- 2 Drag **Power BI Viewer.app** into your **Applications** folder.
- 3 The first time you open it, the Mac may say it **"cannot be opened"**. Click **Cancel** (not Move to Trash).

- 4 Open **System Settings** → **Privacy & Security**, scroll down, and click **Open Anyway**.
- 5 Confirm once. After this, the app opens normally every time.

Sign in (one time only)

- 1 Open the app. You will see the sign-in screen.
- 2 Click the orange **Sign in with Microsoft** button.
- 3 A Microsoft window appears. Enter your **work email and password**, and approve the usual security prompt on your phone if asked.
- 4 You land on the **Home** screen. Done.



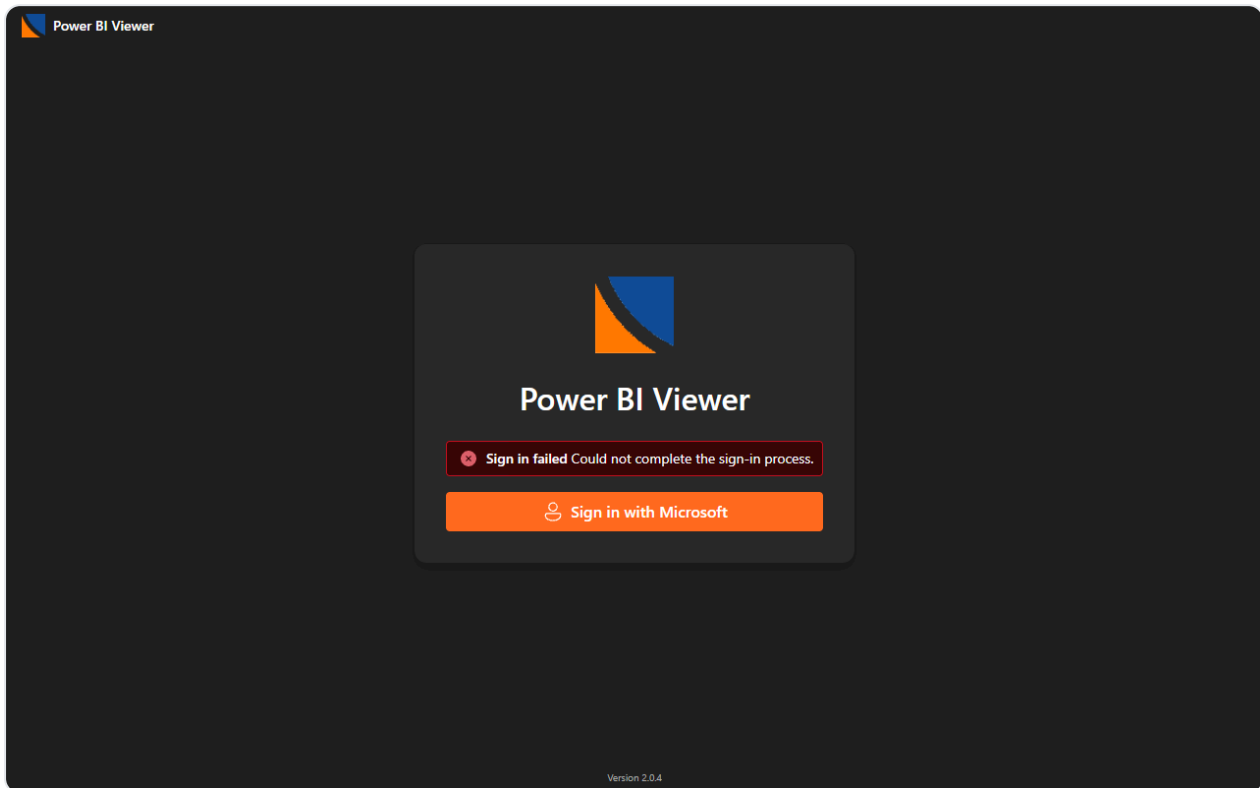
The sign-in screen. One click, your normal Microsoft password, and you're in.

You stay signed in

Your sign-in is stored safely on your computer. The next time you open the app — even after a restart — you go **straight to Home**. You are only asked to sign in again if you sign out, switch accounts, change your password, or leave the app unused for a very long time.

If sign-in fails

A red "**Sign in failed**" bar appears with the reason. Just click **Sign in with Microsoft** again. If it keeps failing, see Troubleshooting.



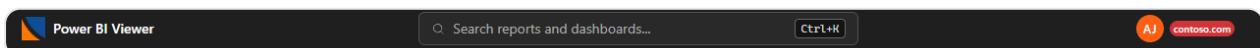
If something goes wrong, a red bar explains why — click the button to try again.

3 Finding your way around

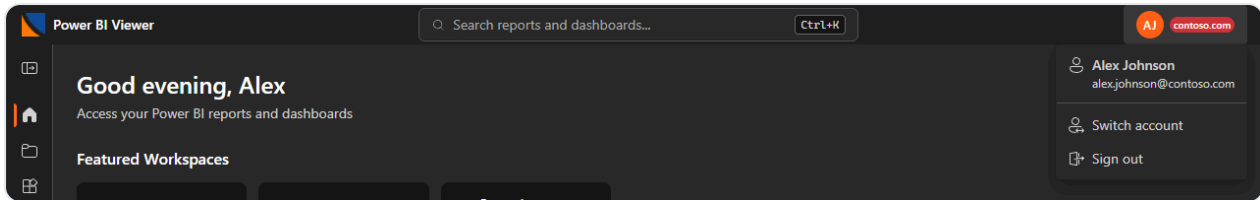
The window has three parts: a title bar across the top, a sidebar on the left, and the main area in the middle.

The title bar (top)

- **Left:** the logo and app name. Drag this bar to move the window.
- **Center:** the search box — "Search reports and dashboards..." — with a **Ctrl** + **K** hint. Click it or press the keys to search.
- **Right:** your **avatar** (your initials in a colored circle) and a badge showing your organization. Click the avatar for **Switch account** and **Sign out**.



The title bar: logo (left), search (center), your account (right).



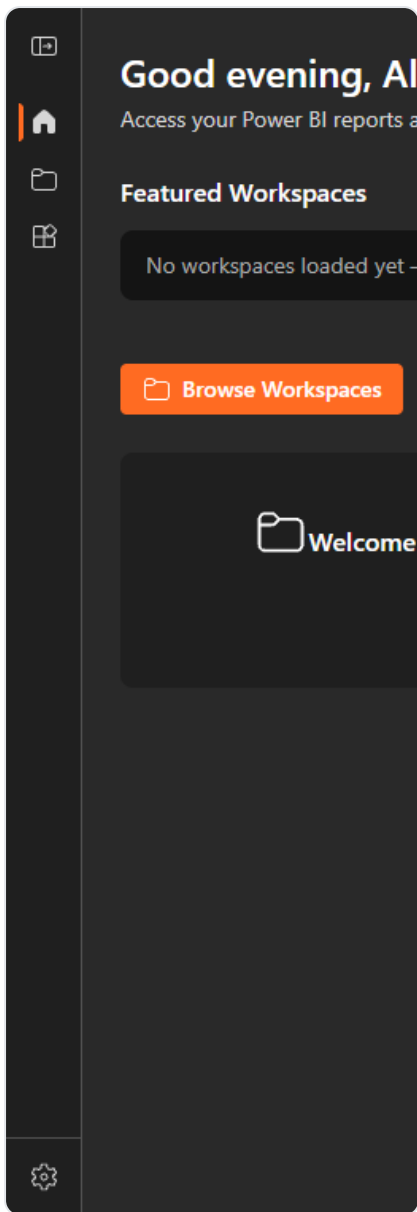
Click your avatar to see your name and email, Switch account, and Sign out.

The sidebar (left)

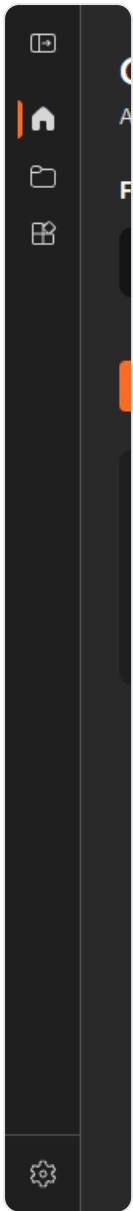
The button at the top expands or collapses the sidebar. Collapsed, it shows only icons — hover over an icon to see its name. The items are **Home**, **Workspaces**, and **Apps**, with **Settings** at the bottom. The screen you are on is marked with an orange bar.

The sidebar starts collapsed

It begins as icons-only every time you open the app. Click the toggle at the top whenever you want the labels back.



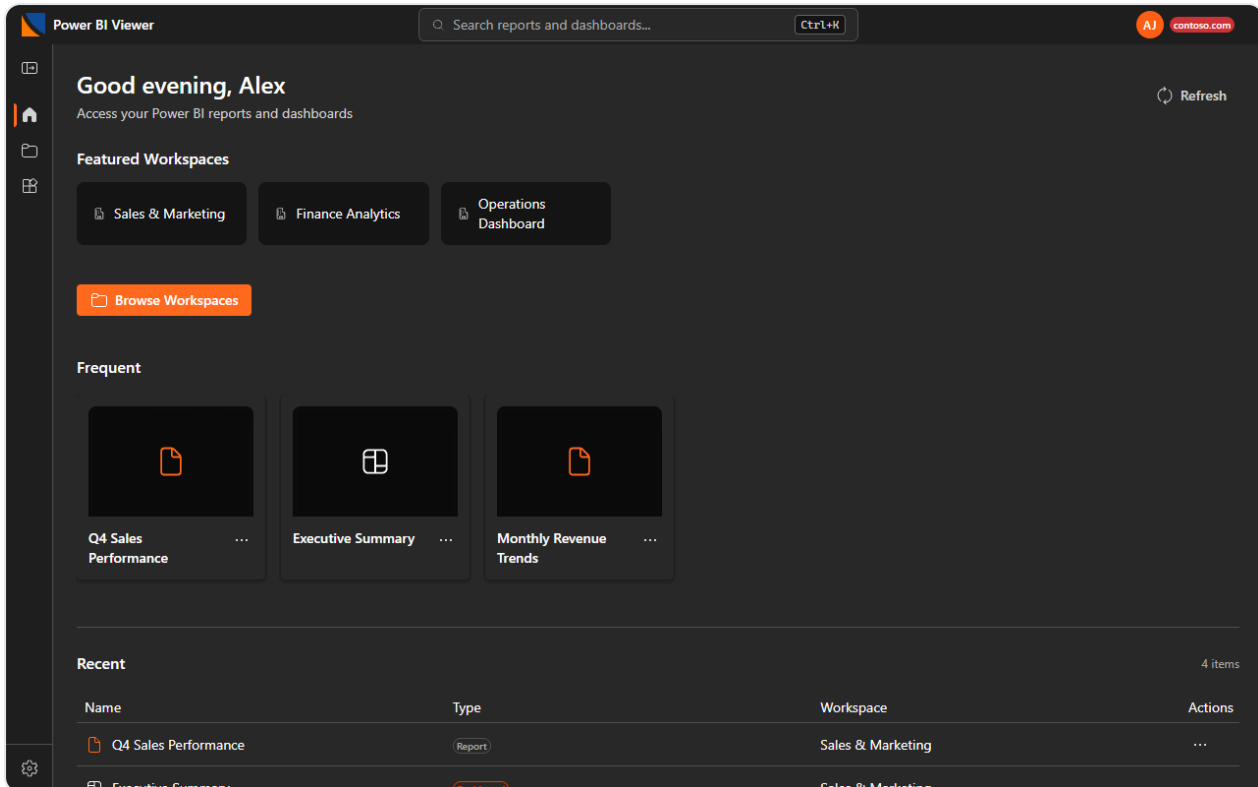
Expanded — labels visible.



Collapsed — icons only (the default).

4 Home

Home greets you by name and gives you quick ways back into your content. A **Refresh** button at the top-right reloads the lists.



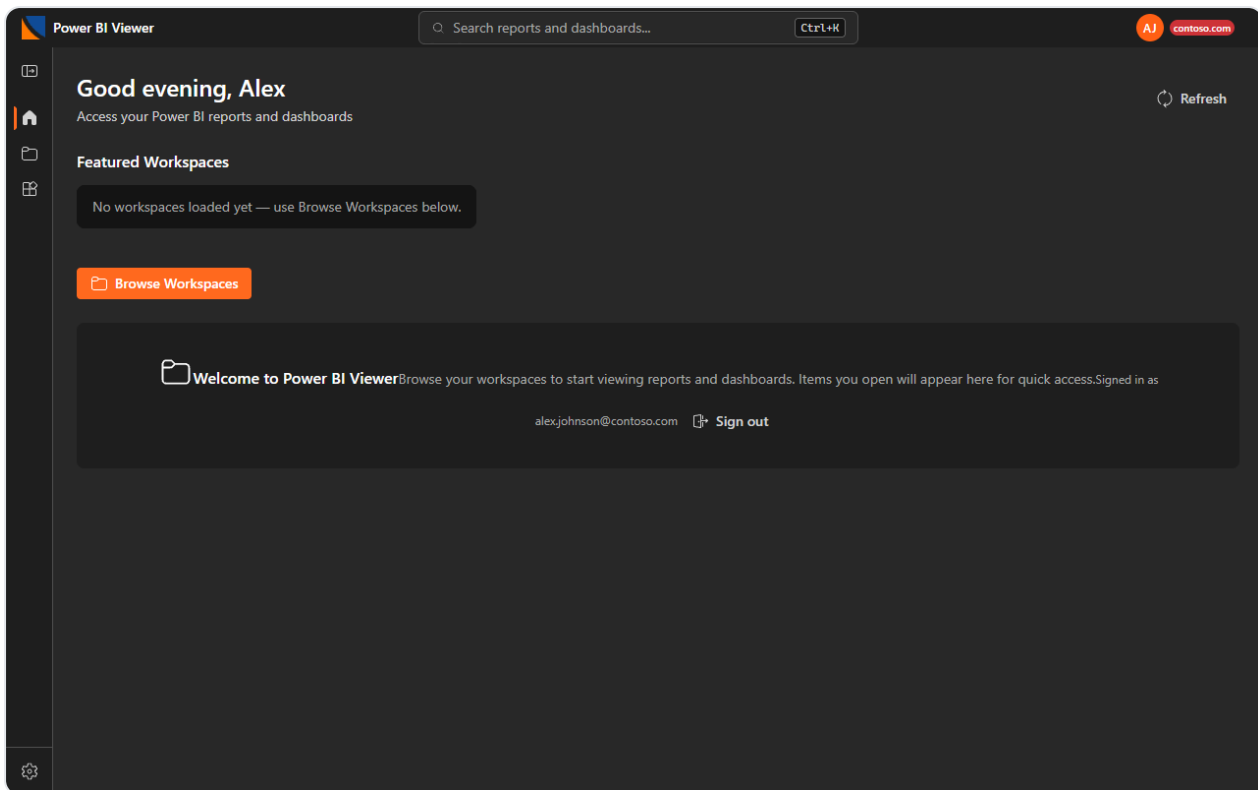
A populated Home: greeting, Featured Workspaces, Browse Workspaces, plus Frequent and Recent.

What's on Home

- **Featured Workspaces** — up to three cards as a quick signpost. Clicking any of them takes you to the Workspaces page.
- **Browse Workspaces** — the orange button, always visible. Your main door into everything.
- **Frequent** — a strip of the items you open most.
- **Recent** — what you opened lately. Each item has an **Open** action and a **Slideshow** action.

First run looks emptier — that's normal

Before you have any history, Home shows a simple Welcome card with your email. Open a few things and the Frequent and Recent areas fill in on their own.



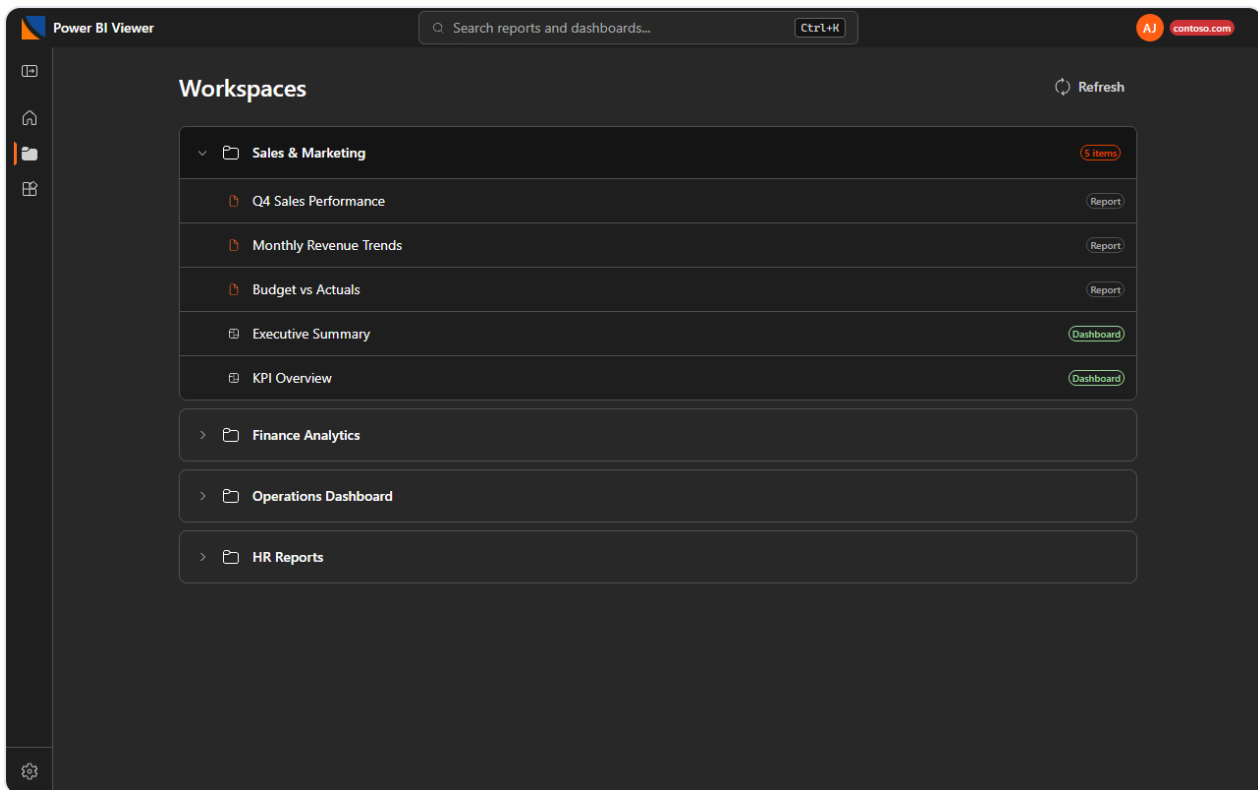
First-run Home, before you have opened anything.

5 Workspaces

The Workspaces page lists every workspace you can see. Click a workspace row to expand it and load what's inside.

- **Reports** — document icon with a *Report* badge.
- **Dashboards** — board icon with a *Dashboard* badge.
- A small **count badge** shows how many items the workspace holds.

Click any item to open it. The **Refresh** button at the top re-fetches the whole list.



An expanded workspace, showing its reports and dashboards.

If something doesn't load: look for **Retry**

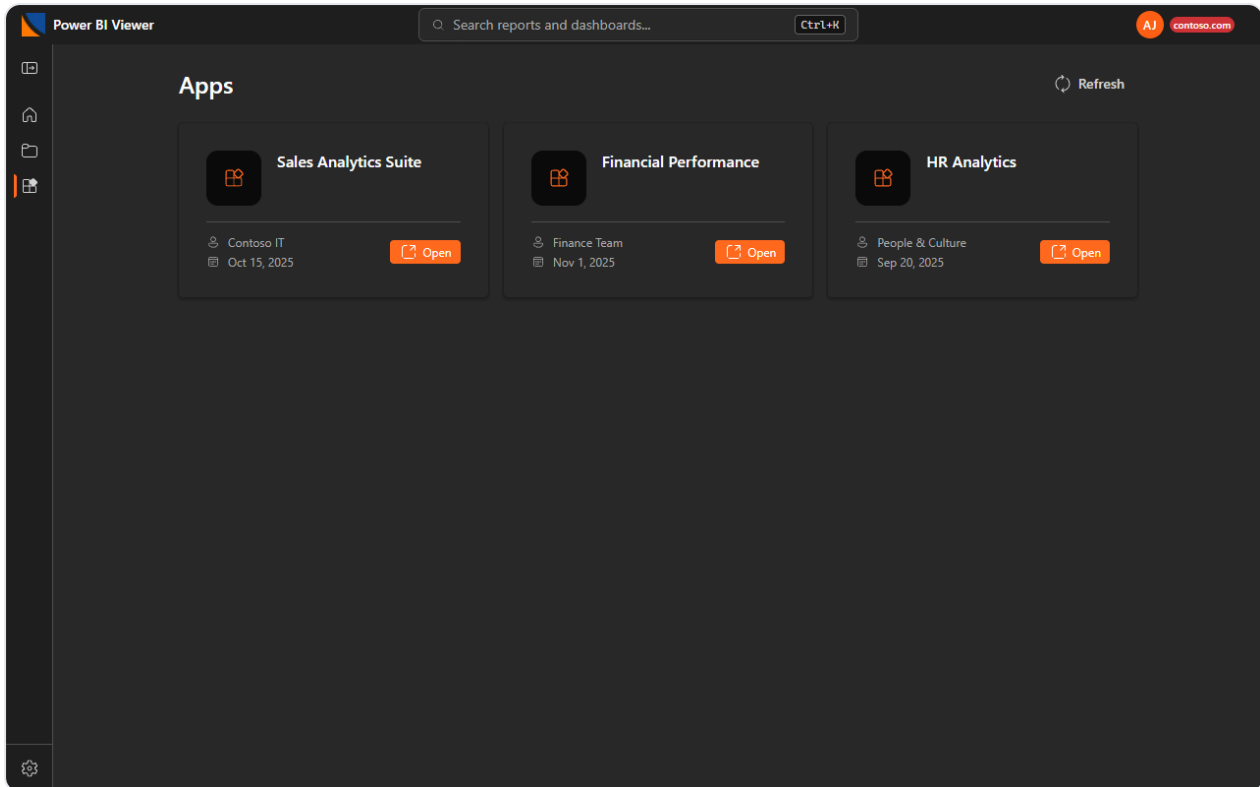
If a workspace's contents fail to load — all of it or just part of it — a small warning row appears in that workspace with a **Retry** button. For example: *"Could not load this workspace. Check your connection or your permissions."* Click **Retry** and it fetches again. The rest of the page keeps working.

6 Power BI Apps

Apps are the polished, packaged way your team delivers a whole suite of reports to you. For most people, this is the main place to work.

The Apps page

Click **Apps** in the sidebar. You see a card for each app — its name, who published it, and when it was last updated — with an **Open** button.



The Apps page. Click Open on any card.

Inside an app

- The app opens as the **full Power BI app experience**, right inside the window — the same menus and navigation you would see on the Power BI website.
- The toolbar above it keeps things simple: **Back to Apps**, the app's name, the data freshness strip, and **Refresh**.
- Because of the shared sign-in, the app **never asks you to log in again**.

Use the app's own menus to move around

Inside an app, navigate with the app's own left-hand menu and tabs — exactly like the web. Use the toolbar's **Back to Apps** button when you want to leave.

Don't see an app you were given?

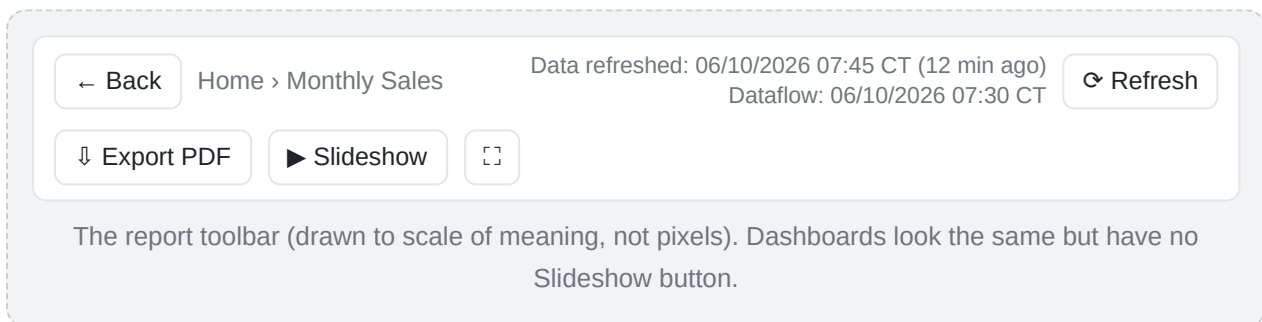
The list only shows apps that are installed for your account. Ask your administrator to push it to you, or open it once on **app.powerbi.com** in your browser, then come back and click **Refresh** on the Apps page. See [Troubleshooting](#).

7 Reports & dashboards

Open a report or dashboard from Home, Workspaces, or Search. A slim toolbar sits above it.

The toolbar, left to right

- **Back** — returns to where you came from. Next to it, a breadcrumb shows "Home > <name>".
- **Data freshness strip** — two small timestamps that tell you how current the data is. This is important enough to get its own section.
- **Refresh** — pulls the latest data. While working it reads "Refreshing..." and is briefly disabled. When it finishes, a green **✓ Updated** appears for a few seconds.
- **Export PDF** — saves the current view as a PDF. See Export to PDF.
- **Slideshow** — reports only. Starts presentation mode. See Slideshow.
- **Full screen** — the corner-arrows icon. Press **Esc** to leave full screen.



Working with a report

- The report keeps its normal Power BI **filters pane** and **page tabs** — use them exactly as on the web.
- In full screen on a multi-page report, the and arrow keys change pages. A small hint in the corner shows the page count.
- When you click **Refresh** on a report, it updates the data **in place** — your current page, filters, and selections are kept.

Working with a dashboard

- Click any **tile** to drill into the report behind it. Use **Back** to return.
- A dashboard draws from several data sources, so its freshness label reads "**Oldest data**" — the age of the *oldest* tile, your "is anything stale?" signal.
- Slideshow is not available on dashboards — it is a report feature.

If something won't load

You'll see a short message and a **Try again** button — click it to reload. If an item was truly deleted, it disappears from your Recent and Frequent lists automatically. More help in Troubleshooting.

8 Is my data up to date?

Every viewer — report, dashboard, or app — shows a small **freshness strip** on the right side of the toolbar. It answers one question at a glance: *how current is what I'm looking at?*

The two timestamps

LINE	WHAT IT MEANS
Data refreshed	When the data behind this screen was last refreshed inside Power BI. A live age in brackets — "(12 min ago)" — ticks up every minute. On dashboards (and apps that bundle several reports) this line is labelled " Oldest data " and shows the oldest source on screen.
Dataflow	When the <i>pipeline that feeds the data</i> last finished bringing in new source data. Think of it as the step before: the dataflow gathers fresh numbers, then the dataset refresh loads them into your report.

Why two timestamps?

A refresh can run on time but re-use old source data. If **Data refreshed** is recent but **Dataflow** is much older, the screen refreshed — but the underlying numbers may not have changed since the dataflow last ran. When both are recent, your data is genuinely current.

What the strip looks like in each state

JUST OPENED (CHECKING...)

Data refreshed: —
Dataflow: —

↻ Refresh

NORMAL

Data refreshed: 06/10/2026 07:45 CT (12 min ago)
Dataflow: 06/10/2026 07:30 CT

↻ Refresh

NEWER DATA HAS BEEN PUBLISHED

• **Newer data available**

Data refreshed: 06/10/2026 08:02 CT (just now)
Dataflow: 06/10/2026 08:00 CT

↻ Refresh

RIGHT AFTER A REFRESH COMPLETES (SHOWS FOR ABOUT 5 SECONDS)

✓ **Updated**

Data refreshed: 06/10/2026 08:02 CT (just now)
Dataflow: 06/10/2026 08:00 CT

↻ Refresh

The freshness strip is always there. The dashes ("—") appear only for the first few moments while the app checks.

Reading the signals

- **"—" dashes:** the app is still checking. The real times appear within moments of opening.
- **• Newer data available** The data behind this screen has refreshed *since you opened it*. The screen is showing slightly older numbers — click **Refresh** to catch up.
- **✓ Updated** A refresh just finished and the screen now shows the latest data. The green confirmation fades after about 5 seconds.
- **⚠ Older than a day** If a timestamp is more than 24 hours old it turns an amber warning color with a ⚠ marker — worth a second look, or a question to your data team.

Auto-refresh: reports update themselves

In **Settings** → **Data Refresh** there is a switch called **Auto-refresh reports**. It is **On** by default, and with it on:

- An open report quietly checks for newer data every few minutes.
- The moment newer data is found, the report **re-pulls it in place** — your page, filters, and selections are untouched.
- You'll simply see the green **✓ Updated** flash. No clicks needed.

With auto-refresh **off**, reports show the orange **• Newer data available** notice instead, and you choose when to click Refresh.

Dashboards and apps don't refresh themselves

A dashboard or app can't be updated invisibly in place, so they always show the "● **Newer data available**" notice when new data lands — click **Refresh** when you see it.

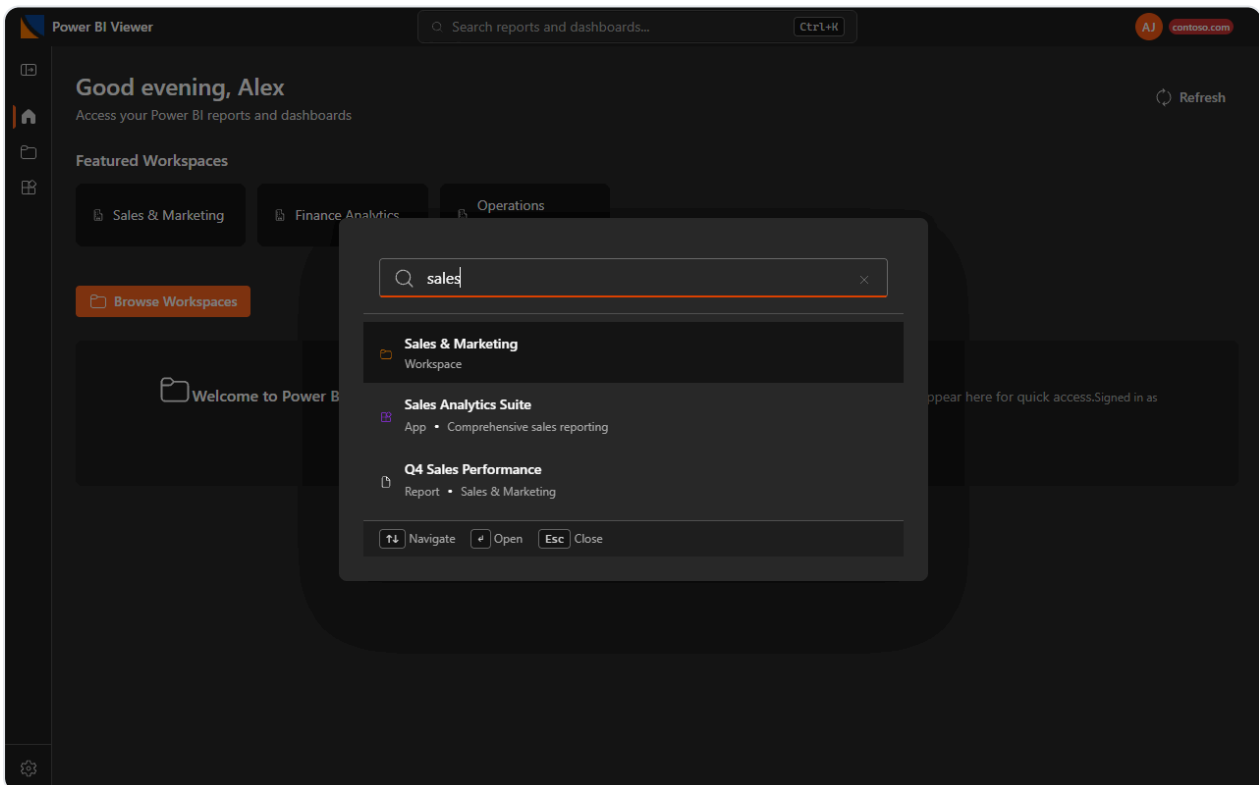
Manual Refresh works the same everywhere

Click **Refresh** any time. The button reads "Refreshing..." while it works, then the **✓ Updated** confirmation appears and the "newer data" notice clears. If nothing seems to happen, wait a few seconds and click again — Power BI ignores refreshes fired within about 15 seconds of each other.

9 Search

Press **Ctrl + K** (**Cmd + K** on Mac) from anywhere, or click the search box in the title bar.

Results appear **as you type**. Each result shows what it is — Report, Dashboard, App, or Workspace — plus the workspace it lives in.



Search shows everything that matches, with type labels and keyboard hints in the footer.

Using the keyboard

-  /  — move through the results
-  — open the highlighted result
-  — close search

Picking a Workspace result

Choosing a workspace jumps you to the Workspaces page with that workspace **already expanded**.

10 Slideshow & wall displays

Slideshow turns a report into a full-screen presentation that advances on its own — ideal for a TV or lobby screen.

Start a slideshow

- 1 Open a **report** (slideshow is for reports only).
- 2 Click **Slideshow** in the toolbar. The report goes full screen.
- 3 Press **Play** to start auto-advancing; **Pause** to stop on a slide.

Slides can be the report's **pages**, its **bookmarks**, or both — choose in Settings → Slideshow.

On-screen controls

The controls fade away after a few seconds while playing; move the mouse to bring them back.

- **Top:** Exit, the current slide name, a counter, and a **gear** to adjust the advance speed on the spot.
- **Bottom:** Previous / Play-Pause / Next, plus dots (or a slider for very long decks) showing where you are.
- A small corner panel lists the keyboard keys.

Kiosk mode — unattended wall displays

Turn on **Auto-start slideshow** in Settings and the slideshow starts playing by itself and runs unattended. In kiosk mode the app:

- Keeps the screen **awake** (no sleep, no screensaver) while playing.

- Hides the mouse pointer after a few seconds of stillness.
- If a slide hits an error, it **retries on its own** until the screen recovers.

How to exit a slideshow

Manual slideshow

(you clicked Slideshow)

Press **Esc** once.

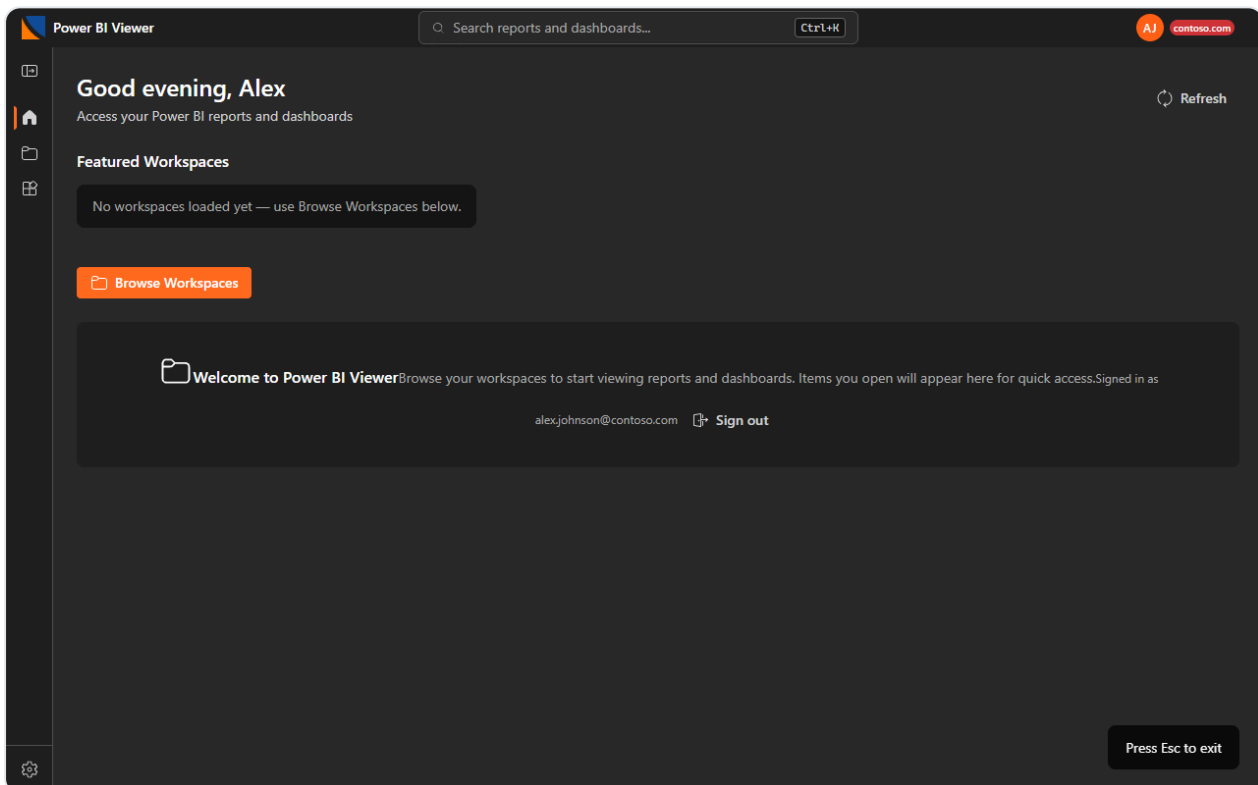
Kiosk / auto-started

(it started by itself)

A single **Esc** tap is **ignored on purpose** so a stray key can't kill the display. To exit: **hold Esc down for 3 seconds**, or press **Ctrl + Shift + Q**.

Always on screen

A faint reminder sits in the **bottom-right corner** the whole time, telling you which exit applies.



The persistent corner reminder. In kiosk mode it reads "Hold Esc 3s to exit / or Ctrl+Shift+Q".

Note the exit keys

It is **Ctrl + Shift + Q** — not **Ctrl + Shift + Esc**, which Windows reserves for Task Manager.

Slideshow keys

- **→** or **Space** — next slide · **←** — previous slide

- **P** — play / pause
- **Esc** — exit a manual slideshow

11 Export to PDF

On a report or dashboard, click **Export PDF** in the toolbar to save what you're looking at.

- 1 Set up the view first — the export captures the **current view**: the active page, plus any filters or selections you have applied.
- 2 Click **Export PDF**. The button reads "Exporting..." while it works.
- 3 A short message appears in the toolbar — for example "Exported to PDF" — when it's done.

Apps can't be exported

Export PDF is available on reports and dashboards. Inside an app, open the specific report you need from a workspace if you want to export it.

12 Your account

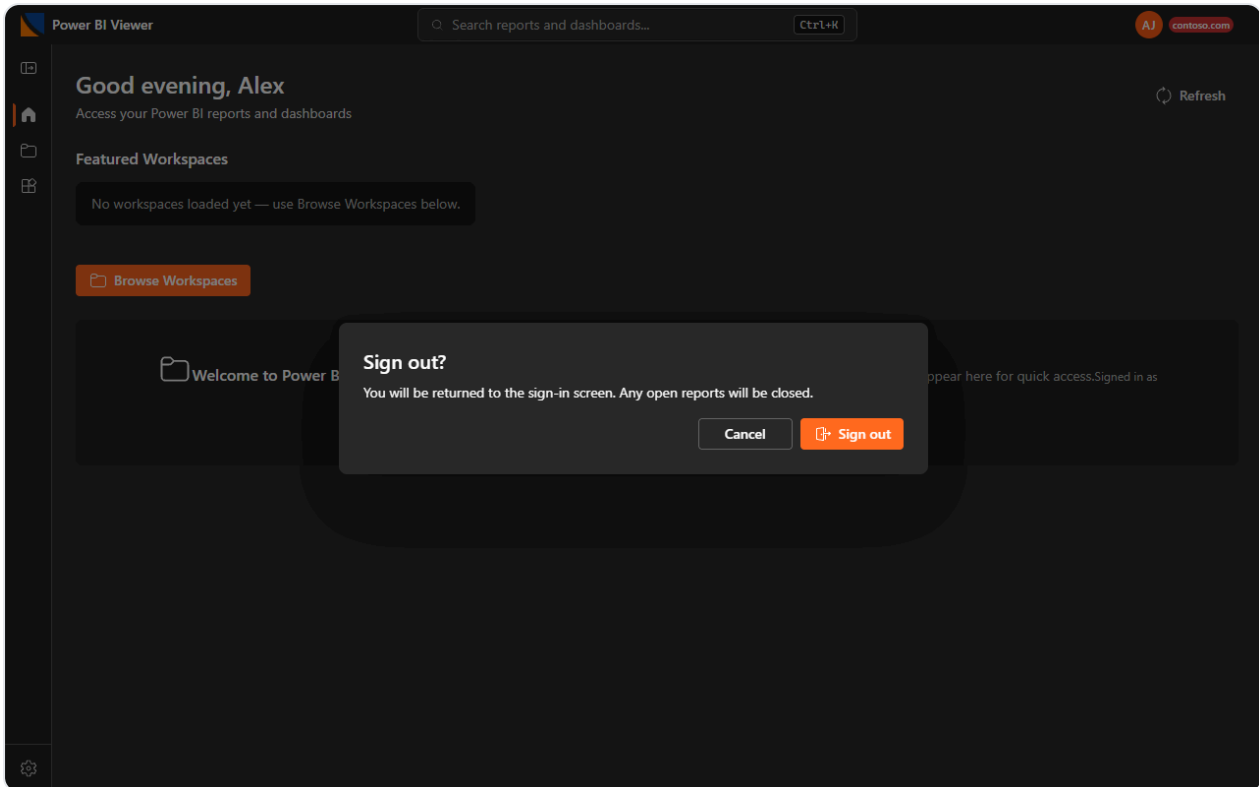
Click your **avatar** in the top-right to see your name and email, with two actions.

Switch account

Switch account signs the current account fully out — clearing everything it left behind, so nothing carries over — and then opens Microsoft's account picker so you can sign in as someone else.

Sign out

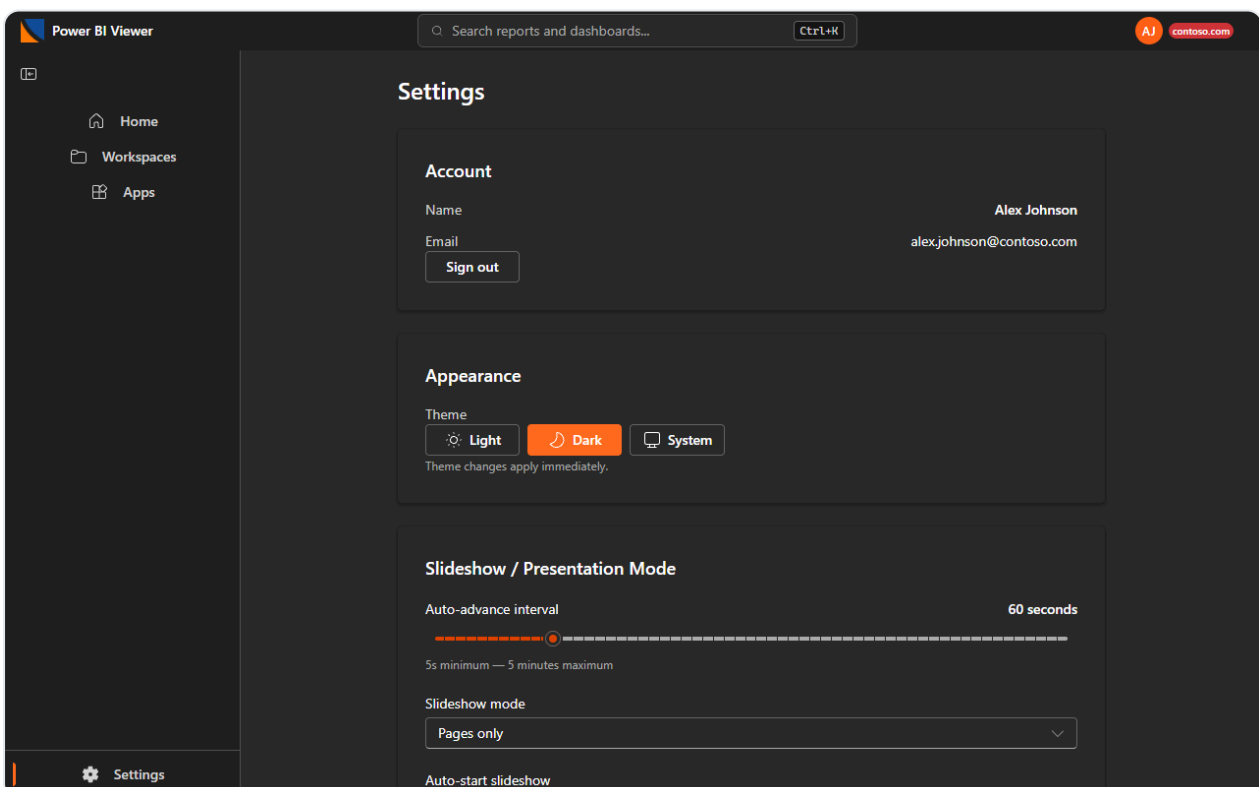
Sign out shows a confirmation: *"You will be returned to the sign-in screen. Any open reports will be closed."* Choose **Cancel** or **Sign out**. There is also a Sign out button in Settings → Account.



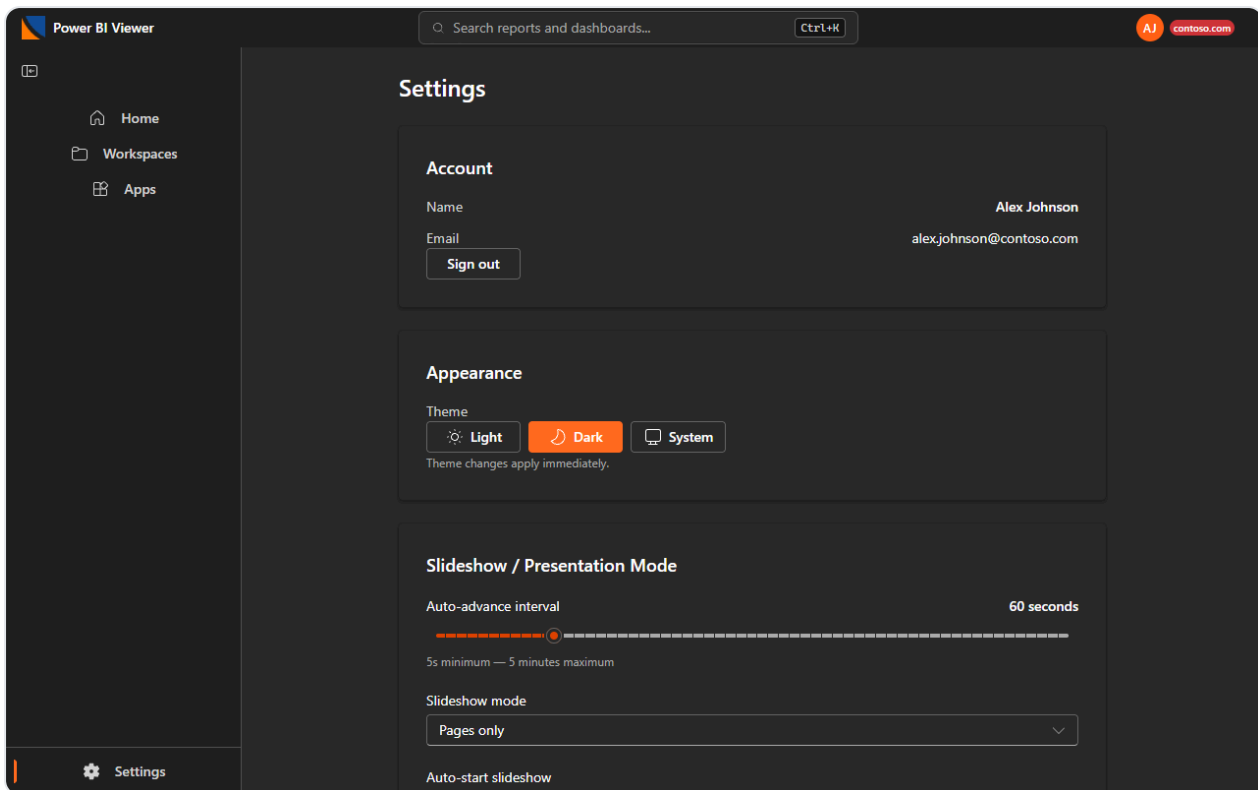
The sign-out confirmation.

13 Settings

Open Settings from the bottom of the sidebar. Changes save and apply immediately.



Settings — top half.



Settings — bottom half. (Your version may show one or two newer options than this picture.)

CARD

WHAT IT DOES

Account

Your name and email, plus a **Sign out** button.

Appearance

Theme: Light / Dark / System. Applies instantly. The app starts out Dark.

Slideshow / Presentation Mode

Auto-advance interval (5 seconds to 5 minutes); **Slideshow mode** (Pages only / Bookmarks only / Pages and bookmarks); **Auto-start slideshow** (On turns on the kiosk behavior described in Slideshow).

Launch on Startup

What the app opens when it launches: **Show home screen**, **Open a specific report**, or **Open a specific app**. A picker appears for the report (from your recent/frequent reports) or the app.

Data Refresh

Auto-refresh reports (On by default) — open reports update themselves the moment newer data is published; see Is my data up to date?. The **Refresh interval** slider (1 minute to 2 hours) sets the refresh pace for slideshows and kiosk displays.

CARD

WHAT IT DOES

Usage History

Clear usage history on sign-out: Never / Always / On shared machine. Plus **Clear usage history now**, which empties Recent and Frequent.

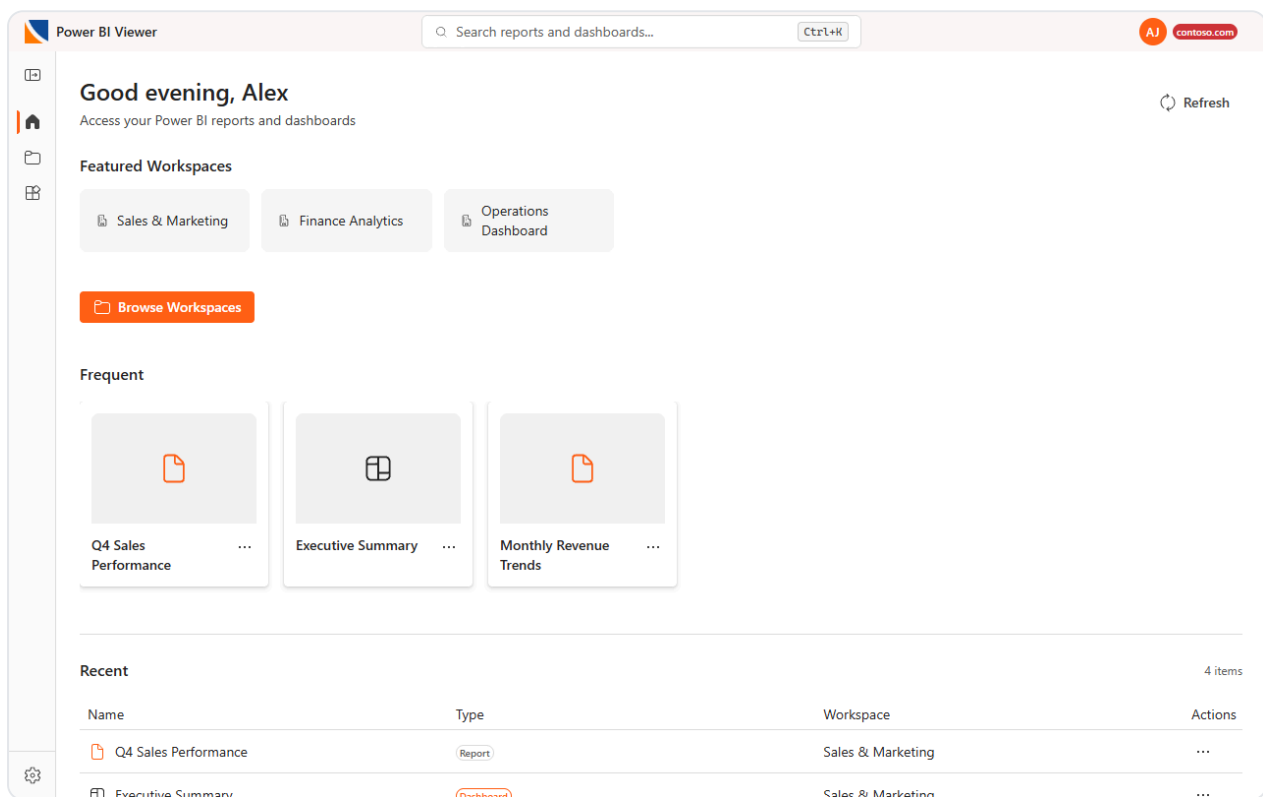
Reset

Reset all settings to defaults. This does *not* sign you out.

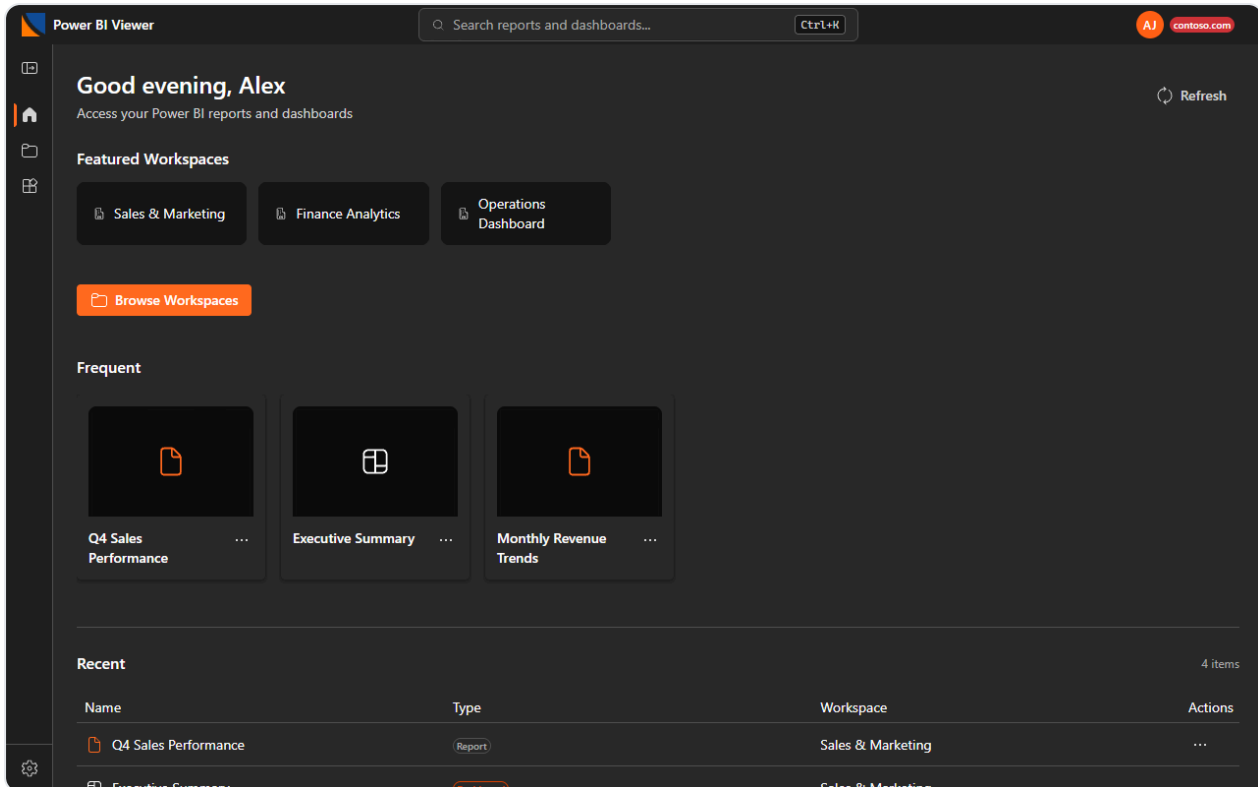
About

Your app version and an **Open user guide** button that opens this guide.

Light vs. Dark



Light theme.



Dark theme (the default).

14 App updates

You don't need to manage updates. Here is what to expect on each platform.

On Windows: it updates itself

- The app quietly checks for new versions in the background and downloads them while you work.
- The update installs **the next time you close and reopen the app**. You won't see installers or progress bars — one day it's simply the newer version.
- Very occasionally an update is urgent. Then you'll see a short message — *"A required update is ready"* — and the app restarts itself within about half a minute to apply it.

On Mac: a polite nudge

- When you open the app and a newer version exists, a message offers a **Download** button.
- Click Download, then drag the new **Power BI Viewer.app** into Applications to replace the old one — the same as installing.
- Choose **Later** if it's a bad moment; it will offer again next launch.

Which version do I have?

Look in **Settings** → **About**. Support may ask for this number.

15 Keyboard shortcuts

WHERE	KEYS	WHAT IT DOES
Anywhere	Ctrl + K (Cmd + K Mac)	Open Search
Search	↑ / ↓ , Enter , Esc	Move, open, close
Report (full screen)	← / →	Previous / next page
Report (full screen)	Esc	Leave full screen
Slideshow	→ or Space / ←	Next / previous slide
Slideshow	P	Play / pause
Slideshow (manual)	Esc	Exit
Kiosk slideshow	Hold Esc 3 seconds, or Ctrl + Shift + Q	Exit (a single Esc tap is ignored)

16 Troubleshooting

Most problems fix themselves with one click — the app always offers a **Try again** or **Retry** button when something fails.

An app is blank, slow, or says "taking too long to load"

Click **Try again** — it reloads the app cleanly and usually works on the second attempt. If the message mentions your connection, a proxy, or a VPN, check your internet (or switch off the VPN) first, then Try again. The first-ever open of an app is also the slowest; later opens are faster.

A report or dashboard won't load

Click **Try again**. If it still fails, you may not have access anymore, or the item was moved or deleted. Items that no longer exist are removed from your Recent and Frequent lists automatically. Use **Ctrl** + **K** search to check whether it's still there under the same name.

"Could not load this workspace" on the Workspaces page

A warning row appears inside that workspace with a **Retry** button — click it. If it says only reports (or only dashboards) failed, the other half still works while you retry. If Retry keeps failing, it's usually a connection blip or a permissions change — try the page-level **Refresh**, and ask your administrator if it persists.

It's asking me to sign in again

Normally you stay signed in across restarts. A new prompt is expected after you sign out, switch accounts, change your password, or leave the app unused for a very long time. Just click **Sign in with Microsoft** again.

Sign-in keeps failing

The red bar tells you why. Most often it's a network hiccup or a closed Microsoft window — just retry. If the message mentions permission or consent, your administrator needs to approve the app for your organization; send them the exact message.

I don't see an app I was given access to

The Apps page only lists apps installed for your account. Two fixes:

- **Easiest:** ask your administrator to push the app to you — then it appears on its own.
- **Self-serve:** open the app once at **app.powerbi.com** in your web browser, then come back and click **Refresh** on the Apps page.

The numbers look old

Check the freshness strip in the toolbar. If you see the orange "● **Newer data available**" notice, click **Refresh**. If "Data refreshed" is recent but "Dataflow" is old, the data pipeline hasn't delivered new numbers yet — that's a question for your data team, not a problem with the app. An amber △ means the data is more than a day old.

I'm stuck in a slideshow

If you started it yourself, press **Esc** once. If it started on its own (kiosk), **hold Esc for 3 seconds** or press **Ctrl + Shift + Q**. The reminder in the bottom-right corner always shows which one applies.

The wall display went dark

The app keeps the screen awake only while the slideshow is actually **playing** — check it isn't paused. If it still sleeps, the monitor's or computer's own power settings are overriding it; ask whoever set up the display to check those.

Support asked me for the log files

The app keeps a small technical log that helps support see what happened. If your Settings page has an **Open log folder** button, click it and send the files. Otherwise you can find the folder yourself:

- **Windows:** press **Win** + **R**, paste `%AppData%\Power BI Viewer\logs`, press Enter.
- **Mac:** in Finder choose **Go** → **Go to Folder...** and paste `~/Library/Logs/Power BI Viewer`.

Send the `main.log` file (and `main.old.log` if present). Logs contain technical events only — not your report data.

Still stuck?

Note your app version (**Settings** → **About**), what you clicked, and the exact message on screen, and send those to your administrator. A screenshot helps a lot.

